Translation of the first maḥberet from Jacob ben El'azar's Sefer ha-meshalim[17]

Scene 1

[1] Lemu'el ben Iti'el[18] *of great deeds of Kabzeel*[19] *told parables*[20] *to provide instruction to those who need it*.[21] It happened when the kings of friendship set forth and the rulers of youth and childhood awakened, I went out to the street where their chariots were, to avenues where they were running, and I saw chariots of love, running like deer.[22] Soldier upon soldier and flag upon flag in hubbub and commotion: they couldn't contain themselves from flowing forward without restraint. After them came the coaches of love, chariot after chariot, and upon one of them was the love of my Soul, *the commander of the army*,[23] *distinguished among many*.[24] Upon seeing me, they ran towards me and hugged me and kissed me. Through all of this my Soul was sleeping. She dreamt that the sun was hugging the bosom of the moon, and she said, "This must mean that my love comes to me and will not be quieted until he sees me".

[17] Translation based on the Hebrew text in Yonah David's edition (Ben El'azar 15-22). The numbers in brackets refer to the line number in that edition. Given that Hebrew was not a spoken language in this period, the text is essentially a clever reconfiguring of biblical Hebrew, with occasional Rabbinic language. As such, it would not be instructive to note every biblical reference. We have instead chosen to include those (in italics in the text) that reflect an interesting repurposing of biblical language in the context of this allegory, i.e., those moments that relate to Neoplatonism and courtly love. Wherever possible, the translation maintains a word-for-word rendering of the original, except for instances in which this impedes the reader's understanding of the text, in which case we have made slight alterations to allow the text to flow more naturally. In this translation we follow Rosen's (*Unveiling Eve* 95-102) division of the story into five scenes.

[18] The name combines two references from the book of Proverbs, 31:1 and 30:1.

[19] 2Sa 23:20 and 1Chron 11:22.

[20] *Meshalim* can also mean fables, allegories or stories.

[21] Is 50:4. This reference is especially important since the *maḥberet* teaches the basics of Neoplatonism.

[22] All variants of the word deer are ubiquitous terms for the lover and beloved in medieval Hebrew literature.

[23] 1Sa 17:55.

[24] Song 5:10. This reference recalls the Song of Songs. At the end of chapter 5 (verses 10-16), there is a description of the beloved groom that features the same expression.

[11] She said in verse:

I slept but my Heart was awake; / hark, the voice of the gazelle knocks.[25]

Doe, stop dozing, / go and cling to your love.

When my Heart heard this, he trembled / and *he could not control himself*.[26]

Scene 2

[15] My Heart became stormy and turbulent in his chamber upon hearing the narration and interpretation of the dream, and he hastened to hide me in the chamber of his heart so that the chariot of the gazelle and his horseman would not see me.[27] My love got up, and all the coaches of his lovers and all the battalions of love surrounding him set their chairs around my Heart. My Soul heard and said, "Let me look through my window and perhaps I will see the gazelle who is the light of my sun, and I will be revived". She fell silent and put on clothes of freedom, opened my chest and my Soul was pleased with her perfumes, all her clothes [fragrant] with myrrh, aloes, cinnamon and cassia. As she went with her young maids, the trains of her delight and the fringes of her pleasures were long. The graceful doe went up and looked here and there, and her love, the gazelle, came to her eyes, the light of his cheeks like lightning, and suddenly it thundered.

[25] Song 5:2. In the Song of Songs 5:2-8, the maiden relates a dream in which her lover came to see her. Since she had already taken off her robe and bathed her feet, she debated whether to open or not. When she finally made up her mind and opened the door, the lover had already gone. The inclusion of this verse in the short poem composed by the Soul has the function of bringing up the biblical story, whose plot is similar to what will happen to the Soul here. It could be argued that Ben El'azar seems to be building his story upon Ibn 'Aknīn's Neoplatonic philosophical commentary on the Song of Songs.

[26] Ge 45:1. This verse refers to Joseph, who could no longer control himself in Egypt and made himself known to his brothers. In a comparative way, the anger of the Heart is going to be known, too.

[27] Heart with a capitalized 'h' refers to the personified figure in the story; heart with a lowercase 'h' refers to the anatomical heart, whether used literally or metaphorically.

[25] She said in verse:

Is this lightning that is running / or is it the face of love whose gleam has shown forth?

Did he plant his desire in me / on the day he traveled, the day he disappeared?

His love runs in me / as a hero runs on his course.

Other lovers will reside in my heart / like transient visitors, but he is a permanent resident,

And others except him are transient, / like a wanderer who travels:

One goes and another comes / and one comes and another flees,

One is wearisome and another cooperative / and one is a burden and another a hassle.

The mouth of the gazelle can heal a wound: / he smears his words on a boil.

[34] After that *she stretched her hand and seized* her love,[28] and he came to rebuke her and shook out his hem. He said to her, "Leave me. Go sojourn somewhere else. Are you not my love? Why didn't you come out to greet me? Did you not know or did you not hear that I came to see you, to enjoy your splendor and the glory of your beautiful majesty? *I rode on swift clouds*[29] *and went on twisted paths, and yet you hid yourself and did not want to be discovered. I was so pained I became ill*:[30] when I came to

[28] De 25:11. Interestingly, the expression is used in the book of Deuteronomy to exemplify a trial: "If two men get into a fight with each other, and the wife of one comes up to save her husband from his antagonist and puts out her hand and seizes him by his genitals…" In this story, the Soul also seizes her lover, though the manner of the seizing is unclear.

[29] Is 19:1. The expression is used in the book of Isaiah to describe the coming of God to Egypt, "mounted on a swift cloud". The lover (i.e., Active Intellect) is coming to the Soul from the Divine world, too.

[30] 2Sa 13:2. The relationship between the Soul and her lover recalls that of Amnon and Tamar in 2Sa 13. It seems relevant, perhaps even a crucial link to prevailing Romance lyric, to mention the 'rape genre' in the Provencal/Occitan troubadour tradition, the *pastourelle*. The classic *pastourelle* describes the typically sexual encounter, often by force, between the

see your face, *you averted your eyes from me*.[31] Now I will return with the chariots of my love since I did not complete what I set for myself to do. You insulted the chariots and battalions of love that surrounded me. But give me one kiss as provision for my return so that it will be my witness". He turned from her to his eye and said, "My eye, my eye, take provisions from her love to save your life and provide for your old age. Get a good long look at her since you have nothing but her appearance".

[46] She said in verse:

Take, oh, my eye, the view of the doe as provisions: / this is your only portion from the beloved.

And you also, my mouth, bid your heart to kiss her: / the intended one will praise you every day.

These are the rules of the lovers of wisdom;[32] / this is indeed the practice.

What bitterness is the departure of the graceful doe / and what hardship to eulogize the separation.

[51] My Soul arose and bowed toward him and *cried and begged him*[33] and said, "Are you not aware that my Heart is my own and that when I talk with anyone he seeks to quarrel with me, and then the vigor of his face changes? He saw me, took me, *brought me to his room*[34] and hid me in his heart; now nobody can see me". The deer returned to his path and was *furious and angry*,[35] and his hands became weak and helpless. When he turned his back

poet (figured as a knight or a shepherd) and a shepherdess; see Deyermond 45 and Paden.

[31] Song 6:5.

[32] The same expression is used in the ninth tale of *Sefer ha-meshalim* to describe the manner in which protagonists Sahar and Kima should love each other.

[33] Est 8:3: The Soul is begging her lover to understand her situation, as Esther begs the king Ahasueros to avert the evil plotted by Haman against the Jews.

[34] Song 1:4.

[35] 1Kings 20:43. The lover leaves furious and angry as "the king left for home furious and

to go, the doe's tears flowed on his cheeks, and she turned to her Heart and said, "Why should I be weeping?" And they exchanged many quarrelsome words.

[57] She said in verse:

Oh, lovers, tell me / how can a lover live without his love?

My heart was placed in the hand of the gazelle; / the gazelle is his keeper.

Can a man without a heart live / when the gazelle carried it off in his hand?

He surely makes it move and laughing as he does so / laughing, mocking his misfortune.

If the eye of the gazelle were to see it[36] / its arrow would puncture his liver.

When he comes to his lover, he's full of complaints / while when he wanders, he laughs upon departing.

When he comes, he is startled and melts / like a moth who leaves.[37]

Thus all of his days are worry / whether he comes or goes.

Scene 3

[66] After these events my Soul was horrified on account of her love, and she quarreled forcefully with her Heart. When I heard of her great fear, I was alarmed, and I hastened to see what was wrong with her. I came to her, and I found her angry and longing for her lover, wrapping herself in the bitterness of separation and gulping the wind opposite his land. I asked of her wellbeing, and she did not answer, nor did she listen. *Then I bowed in*

angry and came to Samaria".

[36] It is not entirely clear what the masculine third person singular pronoun refers to, but it seems to refer to the lover, even though the lover appears in the first person in the first two verses of the poem.

[37] When the gazelle comes the beloved is startled.

homage to her,[38] but all of this was useless. The attendants said to me, "You should know: she is sick with love and spoke unkind words of you". And when I heard that she spoke of me, my heart died in my insides. I became angry and said, "Is it not a shame to hide my wrongdoing in my bosom?" My Heart changed its attitude and was seized with trembling when he heard my words. He said, "Give in quickly. *Don't refuse to go to her*.[39] Please don't avoid looking at her, [even if] she won't look at you because you deprived her of love. *Return to your lady and submit to her harsh treatment*".[40] Before he completed his council *Jacob awakened from his sleep and said*,[41] "Slowly *I touch the pupil of my eye*.[42] *I was mistaken*".[43]

[78] I said in verse:

Can a lover be angry at his beloved and swear / on the life of love? Were it not for my Heart I would have killed you.

My Soul lied to her. I am not like a lover: / only yesterday I knew you as the most faithful.

This is the code of lovers: if the doe curses / her lover responds: I ransomed you in my soul![44]

[38] Ge 24:48.

[39] Nu 22:16.

[40] Ge 16:9: Sarai gives Hagar to Abram as a concubine and she conceives. Sarai worries she will be lowered in Hagar's esteem and with Abram's permission to treat Hagar as she wishes, Sarai then treats her harshly, and Hagar runs away. Later, an angel of God finds Hagar in the wilderness and says to her, "Go back to your mistress, and submit to her harsh treatment". As the Heart in this story sees it, this is the same harsh treatment that the author is receiving from the Soul.

[41] Ge 28:16. Although this is a reference to biblical Jacob, here it also refers to the author of the work.

[42] Zec 2:12. The biblical quotation refers to the Babylonians who dare to do anything against the people of Zion. Here, to touch the pupil of one's eye means to hurt oneself, and, in Jacob's case, to hurt oneself by being mistaken.

[43] Is 44: 20. Literally: "The thing in my right hand is a fraud".

[44] The notion of a lover's code seems to be a romance concept. This concept appears repeatedly in Ben El'azar's ninth story in this same collection.

Scene 4

[82] I arose in haste, worry and trembling. I was submissive and not proud. I hurried and did not linger. I *came to her in secret*,[45] calling, "My Soul, my Soul, *my faultless dove*",[46] and I said to her and her attendants, "Why are you angry with your slave, and why have you said things that were not correct? In fact, each day man sins against man, and son does shameful things, yet he is silent". My Soul responded and spoke to me harshly, saying, "Do you compare people and souls? So what if man sins against man –they are both made of dust! How does the son of Molekh compare to the son of a king?[47] Was I not cut out of a precious stone, a priceless quarry?" Her appearance was terrifying, her aspect beautiful.

[90] She said in verse:

From on high my source gives off precious light, / from even before the day of creation,

But[48] my Creator sent part of my source to a body / of man *to remove evil deeds from man*.[49]

For can a body be compared to a clump of earth, whose / source is of this kind, taking refuge in the shadow of his lord?

[94] When my Heart heard, I was upset; my anger rose, and my fury became great and struck my hand. *He replied stormily*,[50] saying, "How can those who dwell in houses of clay be proud?" He said to her, "I concede to you that your glory is vast, your honor is great, the foundation of your

[45] Ru 3:7.

[46] Song 5:2 and 6:9.

[47] Molekh is the biblical name that refers to an ancient god of child sacrifice. David (Ben Elʿazar 118) says that *ben Molekh* is a pejorative way to define a male prostitute.

[48] The edition reads *'ekh* (how) but *'akh* (but) makes it logical.

[49] Job 33:17. According to Neoplatonic philosophy, one of the goals of the rational soul was to lead the human being to perfection by ruling over both the vegetative and animal parts of the soul.

[50] Job 38:1: God replies to Job from out of the storm.

origin is pure, even lofty. Your preciousness excels beyond me, your shape is pure and you are a diadem of glory. And yet, aren't you aware that your glory and splendor have been stolen from you? Yes, your figure is formed from a good form, and he put on you a splendid crown. His light sheds light on you and his splendor radiates on you: for one high official is protected by a higher one. Yes, your foundation and the foundation of your foundation are lofty. Nevertheless, there are ones greater than them. And yet, as long as you are living here, I am your room, and you are placed in my station. In my midst you dwell: you carry me and I am your burden. You are my lord, and I am your prophet. I tell of your radiance and integrity, of your honesty and brightness, of your glory and majesty, and of your great wealth. If it were not for the fact that you dwell in an earthen body, you would be nonexistent. I am *your resting place*,[51] you are my lord, and I am your messiah. So why do you treat me with contempt and why do you belittle me?" Then I rebuked my Heart and cursed him on hearing him speak haughtily and grandiloquently, and I said, "What has gotten into you to speak in such a raised and lofty manner? Do not seek such great things. This is how souls talk. It is true that they are the same type of form as their Creator, but they have set their homes far from their Creator and there is a valley between them. So what right do you have to speak such and to compose such? You indeed are a weakly body and defeated corpse to be dumped and trampled. How is it possible for mere mud and mortar to compete with the soul?

[112] I said in verse:

The form of man is like nothing / and the source from which he is hewn is just evil,

[51] 1Chron 28:2. The body is the resting place of the Soul, as David wants to build a worldly resting place for the Ark of the Covenant of God.

And from four elements he [is made],[52] / only four and no more, no less.[53]

[115] When my Soul heard the abominable and despicable words of my Heart, my spirit became faint on account of my words. My Soul responded to me, "Don't be angry at me for talking to you harshly, for I spoke words of wisdom, and my wise words were like spurs. But I spoke to you in anger and out of my great anguish and distress, and in fact the wrong done to me is your fault, and thus I am quarreling with you because you are jailing me in your dungeon, and you do not show me my beloved among the gazelles. I heard about him, that he clings to another graceful doe and embraces the bosom of another girl. I heard about her with my own ears that she is a delight to the eyes. If only someone would tell me her name, her image, her nature, and her form". My Heart[54] said, "Is not wisdom his beloved? Upon her is his desire, and now I lay my plea before you: Please, let my soul be dear in your eyes. Please, let us go alone, leave, and we will ask for her path, where to find it, and once there we will be quenched by the breast of wisdom.[55] Let us delight in lovemaking of wisdom, knead the breast of intellect, cover ourselves with the hair of love, and that's how we will be successful,[56] and *we will graze in the gardens and collect lilies*[57] *and draw out the wisdom from pearls, and we will descend to the garden of delight. Perhaps the delightful lover will happen upon us*".[58] I shouted and cried out in great bitterness, saying, "Where am I going to get the strength? Know and see that you are conspiring against me. How could you say, 'Let us descend to the garden or rise up?' I am a poor and miserable man".

[52] Medievals considered man to be made of the same four elements that the world is made of: fire, earth, air and water.

[53] Literally "whatever is added will be taken away".

[54] It seems that *li* ("to me") is a scribal error for *libi* ("my heart").

[55] *ʿOrma*, the word used here for wisdom, can have negative connotations, associated with cunning, or a sinister side of wisdom.

[56] The phrase is literally "and succeed and do" but seems in context to be an example of hendiadys.

[57] Song 6:2.

[58] Nu 23:3. The biblical verse refers to God, and not to the delightful lover.

[131] I said in verse:

Can wisdom be sought from a fool / and what wisdom belongs to the fool?

Can you ask bread from a starving person / and a thirsty man for water?

One who seeks wisdom in the heart of a fool / indeed carries the sin of blame,

And what is the wisdom of a fool / when the fool's is so abundant?

Does one seek a clod of earth in heaven / and does one seek the Pleiades[59] in hell?

What do the body and the intellect have in common? / Wisdom is suitable for the soul alone.

The body is a garden of sloth / and its only fruit is slumber and sleep.

[139] My Soul responded, saying, "I also acknowledge your splendor; speak, for I want to see you exculpated". She arose shouting, sighed and said, "Why am I shouting and sighing and what am I crying about? It is because you were being lazy in your days of vigor, and you did not make orchards and gardens for yourself. Did you not know that sleep dresses people in rags, and laziness lulls you to sleep? Remember when I said to you, 'Acquire wisdom and reside with wisdom'. You responded to me in words of complaint and a tiring clamor, saying, 'Wisdom is too remote for any creature. How can I seek it when it is not available? We only know it by rumor, but no one [really] knows it'. Indeed the intellect resides in a lofty place, dwells afar, so much so that you were left naked without clothing from wisdom, and you went and sat apart from it. It is true that since you spoke lies and composed lying words, you quarreled with words of folly. You have taken up lodging in the shadow of foolishness. You chose for yourself the way of backsliding. The lazy man says, 'There's a lion in the road'. He who pursues the intellect may attain it but might not know it. He

[59] We read *kima* (the Pleiades) instead of *rima* (lie) for the sake of the meaning.

only sees a hint of it, and though *wisdom is set high up*,[60] the wise ones can lower it from there using their cunning. Even though the soul may dwell with it and belong to it, it will be revived in its shadow and will take shelter under its wings, where it will proclaim to man what to do. If you return your spirit to her, she will converse with you".

[154] Upon hearing her words, my spirit became very upset as if birth pangs were upon it. I was dumbstruck and dumbfounded, and also embarrassed and ashamed: I put my hand to my mouth, my face fell, and I became upset, until her mercy was stirred on my behalf, and she said, "*Let Jacob not be embarrassed now, let not his face turn pale*.[61] Though you were lazy and fell asleep, do not let anyone lose heart. For I saw the garden of wisdom planted, sown in the seed of wisdom, and the thirst-quenching spring irrigated. Arise, and set our heart to the path on which he has walked, and he will teach us his ways. We will explore and seek out his ways and go to his roads". When I heard all of this, I said, "Who is he whose heart God touches?" She answered me, "A man who has spirit in him. Indeed you saw the chariot of love upon which was *the commander of the army*,[62] *distinguished among many*.[63] He planted and sewed, and wisdom called him her companion. All day long I am upset that he bears me a grudge and *that his glory is exiled from me. Why should we stare at each other*?[64] *Let's go to the seer*.[65] Indeed with his speeches *he binds up wounds*,[66]

[60] Eccles 10:6. The author has modified the original quotation: the word *sekhel* (folly) appears instead of the word *śekhel* (wisdom), as it does here.

[61] Is 29:22. In Isaiah, Jacob refers to the people of Israel, but as David notes (Ben Elʿazar 120), Jacob might also refer to the author himself.

[62] 1Sa 17:55.

[63] Song 5:10

[64] Ge 42:1.

[65] 1Sa 9:9. Schirmann and Fleischer (252) claim that this "seer" is indeed Maimonides, who tried to find common ground between religion and philosophy: his *Guide for the Perplexed* proposes to lead the Soul to the Active Intellect.

[66] Job 5:18. The biblical verse refers to God; the implied meaning in this story is to Maimonides (Schirmann and Fleischer 252).

sweeter than honey. I'm not going to name his name because of the jealousy of enemies. Certainly I lament his absence due to his wandering, and it hurts me now".[67]

[168] She said in verse:

My love moved away from me / and my eyes poured down water on account of his wandering.

Through them the garden of lovers is watered, / the garden that my lover planted in my soul.[68]

Indeed his heart walks around in it / and he has made a couch for himself.

He remembered the days of ancient times; / he remembered the lover with whom he took pleasure.

I ripped open my heart and split it / because separation from my beloved has torn it.

Scene 5

[174] I said, "Ah, my Soul, what will help you when pains come upon you? With what are you endowed? How long will you go on disconsolate?" She responded, saying, "Now you ridicule me. Did you not know that you comforted me with empty words?" I begged her and said, "*Please, I was foolish to be presuming to speak in your presence*.[69] Remove your anger, and

[67] Maimonides' name is not mentioned in this text. The Soul says that she does not mention his name "because of the jealousy of enemies". This might refer to the Maimonidean controversy (Schirmann and Fleischer 252) that arose before the composition of the story: several members of the Jewish community in Provence, and in other places, rebelled against some of Maimonides' works, accusing him of dangerously merging Greek philosophy and Jewish tradition, putting the Jewish religion in danger and misleading the Jewish people.

[68] A syllable is missing in this hemistich. Although David suggests (Ben El'azar 20) the preposition *ki* (as or like), *bi* (in) seems to make more sense in context.

[69] Ge 18:27, 31. This seems to be a hendiadys. This, rather than "I was foolish and I was pleased to speak to you", is the intended meaning.

I will speak to you this last time.[70] Tell me your origin and from whence come your wisdom and your splendor". And she said, "I will tell you[71] about the foundation of souls and their source and *well-guarded secrets that you don't know about*".[72]

[180] She said in verse:

God is the exalted / and is the most wonderful of all wonders.

He is the beginning of all beginnings / and is without beginning and without end.

He created everything in wisdom / and carries with much mercy.

The Intellect is the first of His action / and the soul rises after it.

There are three souls / and the rational soul has been set above the others.[73]

Below her there is an animal soul / and a vegetative soul near it.

And given this threefold division / there are three levels of action:

To make her wise, to feed her / and to make her grow physically.

The heavens and the stars, / He created them going around forever:

As the heavens rotate / they come into being before first sources;

All of them are the foundation of every living thing / and every stone and every tree,

[70] Ge 18:32. The biblical verse refers to Abraham's final inquiry to God of what God would do upon finding ten innocent people within the city of Sodom. God answers that He would not destroy the city for the sake of the ten. In this text, Jacob asks the Soul about its origins and secrets for a final time, just as Abraham poses a final question.

[71] It seems that a verb is missing here. Instead of reading, "I to you", the beginning of the quotation ought to read, "I will tell you".

[72] Is 48:6. The author compares the situation in Isaiah 48, in which God reminds Israel that He is their God and Creator, to the Soul who will tell Jacob about the secrets of its origin (Neoplatonism).

[73] The next three verses are extremely problematic; while the general meaning can be gleaned in context (the three parts of the soul), the verses themselves lack sense.

But not everything that is truly living: / rather, everything that dies.

He placed the world in the midst of the heavens; / He hung the earth on nothingness.

All of these things God created in speech / until He was finished speaking.

Know that they are all attached to each other; / one depends on the other,

He arranged for these luminaries / to get light from the eternal light.

One light is higher than another / and who can reach the outermost light?

They will never end, they will never wear out, / they will never perish,

But the four sons will perish / for they can become sickly:

The source of the one is opposite the other / and why has he become angered?

Their work will perish for this reason / and [explains] why their deeds are the deeds of exile:

It can be likened to a pot of four that is not cooked.

[203] All of these worlds have been created, and every one of the worlds is established on its foundation, each rank opposite its rank, and the whole work is complete.

The parable of the Intellect is complete / it has been made using the themes of love.

Think of this well; if you think evil of this / you will bear your own guilt.

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